PROJECT 5 - ART BIBLE

Visual reference pack. Supersedes the Art direction section of GDD.pdf.

The concept, in one line

A knight armed with a giant pen nib fights his way out of an illuminated manuscript. The enemies are medieval marginalia come to life - the hare archer, the armoured snail, the grotesque hybrid - and the final boss is an ink-wraith scribe. The dungeon is a scriptorium: candles, quills, loose pages, and spreading pools of black ink.

Technique

Hand-inked illustration, not 3D and not pixel art. Bold black ink contour lines of varying weight, flat to lightly-washed colour inside them, visible paper grain. Muted, limited palette. Everything is drawn from a fixed 3/4 top-down view so it reads on a tilemap.

Measured palette

Clustered from the reference images by pipeline/extract_palette.py - not picked by eye.

SIGNAL (gameplay - never on scenery)

- Nib Teal #35D6C4
  Player shots, the pen-nib glow, power-ups
- Hostile Magenta #FF2E6E
  Enemy bullets. Nothing else, ever.
- Plume Ember #F06A2A
  Hero plume, candle flame, explosive barrels
- Graze Gold #FFC93C
  Graze meter, graze sparks, Shockwave ring

WORLD (environment)

- Parchment #E2C5A8
  Paper, cape, gilt filigree, UI text
- Candle Warm #BE9E91
  Lit wall near a candle, warm floor pool
- Stone Lit #8A8088
  Floor in light - the room's dominant value
- Stone Mid #776B70
  Wall faces
- Stone Shadow #554F59
  Wall shadow, floor away from light
- Ink Violet #3C2C39
  Deep shadow, recesses
- Ink Black #18030A
  Ink pools, outlines, the void

CREATURE + HERO

- Creature Violet #886181
  Enemy flesh, fur, slug bodies
- Creature Rust #BA7977
  Enemy hide, shells, cloth
- Deep Plum #421C39
  Enemy shadow side
- Steel #868178
  Hero armour

Generated by pipeline/make_art_bible.py - re-run after changing the references.

RULES

Hostile Magenta is for enemy bullets and nothing else.

This is the hardest rule in the project and it survives the art change unaltered. The core mechanic is grazing within 20 px of a bullet. If a bullet is ever ambiguous against scenery, the mechanic stops working. No scenery, no creature, no prop may be magenta or pink.

Teal belongs to the player.

The nib glow, the player's shots and the damage power-up. The hero is the only warm-steel-and-teal thing on screen, so he never gets lost in a room full of violet creatures.

The environment stays desaturated and mid-value.

Reference floors cluster around #8A8088 and #554F59 - grey-violet, low contrast, no busy texture where bullets travel. Ornament lives on the WALLS, where nothing is dodged. The floor earns its interest from light and ink pools, not from pattern.

Warm light, cool world.

Candles and the light shaft push amber into a violet-grey room. That contrast is what makes the painted references feel lit rather than flat. Light direction is fixed: key from the top-left.

Ink is the theme and the threat.

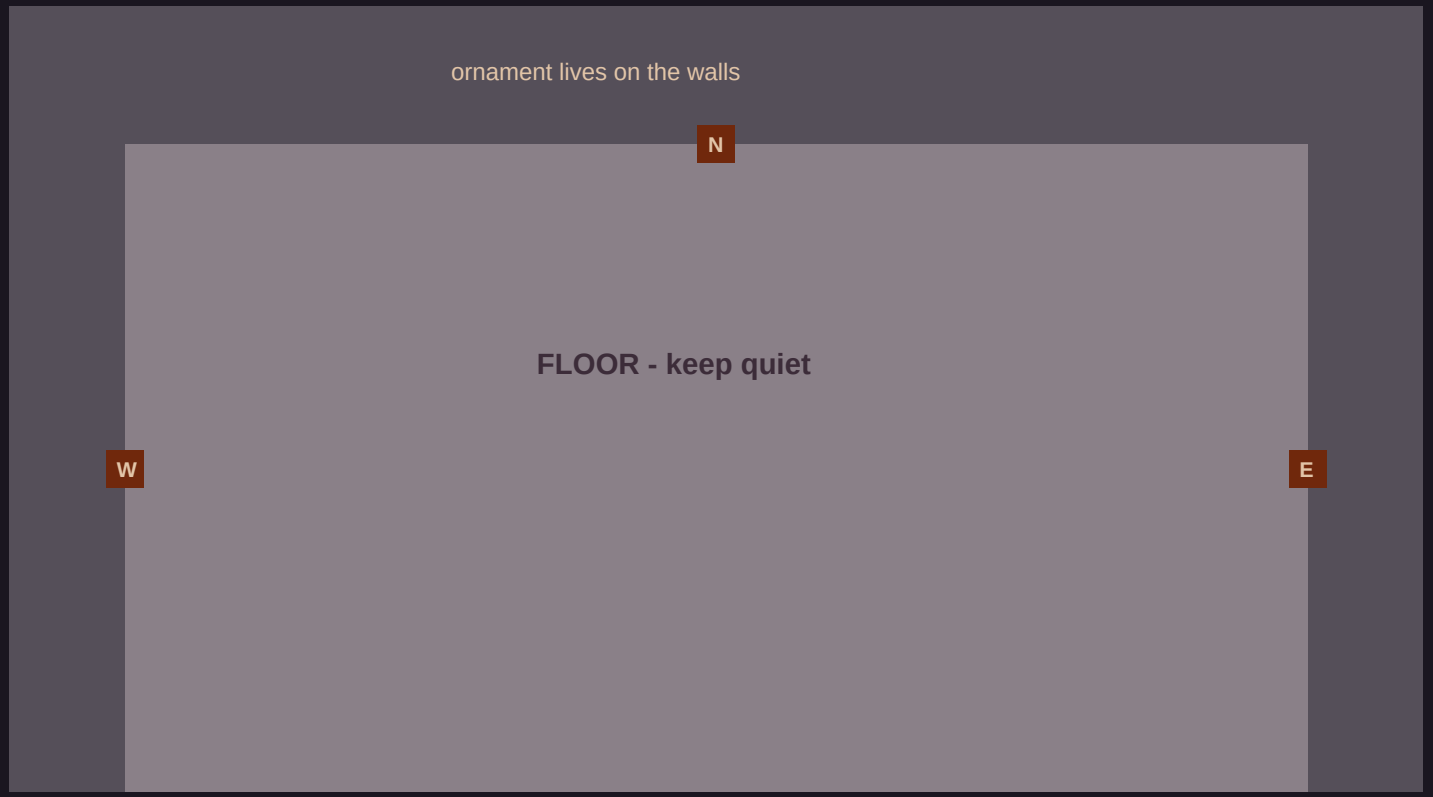
Black ink pools on the floor, drips off the boss, and splatters where things die. It doubles as the darkest value in the palette, so it always reads.

Silhouette first.

Each enemy must be identifiable as a black shape: the snail is a circle on a wedge, the hare is tall ears over a thin body, the rat-demon is a hunched arc with a long tail. If two enemies share a silhouette, one of them is wrong.

ROOM BRIEF

Full spec in docs/ROOM_BRIEF.md. Hit this framing and a new room needs no engine work at all.



1152 x 640 canvas - floor x 94..1058, y 112..640 - no south wall: the floor runs off the bottom edge

Append to every room prompt

top-down 3/4 orthographic view of a gothic scriptorium chamber, hand-inked illustration with bold dark contour lines and flat painterly colour, ornate gilt vine filigree and arched timber doors on the stone walls, plain low-contrast grey-violet flagstone floor, spilled black ink pools and scattered manuscript pages, warm candlelight from the upper left across cool stone, limited palette of grey-violet stone, parchment cream, gold and ember orange, no magenta, no teal, no text, clean readable composition, empty centre

Rules

Fixed 3/4, 45 deg, ORTHOGRAPHIC.
Walls do not converge.
Three walls: top, left, right.
Ornament on walls. Floor stays plain - bullets fly there.
Warm candlelight from top-left across cool grey-violet stone.
Ink pools and loose pages, flat on the floor, never tall.

Never on scenery

- #FF2E6E - enemy bullets only
- #35D6C4 - the player's colour

ENVIRONMENT - the master reference (highest priority)



This sets the look for everything. Room as a shallow diorama: floor as a quadrilateral with three walls visible, not a flat square of tiles. Ornate gilt vine filigree and arched doors on the walls; the floor left plain grey-violet so bullets read. Warm candle light with a visible shaft falling across cool stone. Scattered storytelling props - loose pages, quills, a candle, a dropped flower - and spilled ink pools. Four doors, one per wall, matching the GDD's room model.

GAMEPLAY REFERENCE - arena, readability, bullet colour



Take the READABILITY from this, not the pixel technique. Note what it proves: magenta bullets and teal player shots are legible against grey-violet stone at speed; the floor's mandala inlay is low-contrast enough to dodge over; ink pools sit flat on the ground and never compete with projectiles; ornament is on pillars and edges, away from the fighting space. Bounded arena, whole room on screen at once.

HERO - the Nib Knight (the anchor asset)



The only hero reference. Stocky, large-helmed proportions: head and helm roughly a third of total height, short legs, broad stance. Steel plate (#868178) kept almost colourless, tattered parchment cape (#E2C5A8), and exactly two points of colour - the ember plume (#DD976D to #F06A2A) and the teal pen-nib (#98E5DD to #35D6C4). The nib is the weapon and the brightest thing on him; it is what the player's eye tracks. Every other asset is checked against this one for scale, line weight, light direction and palette.

PROPS - the three interactive objects, plus the power-up



Maps one-to-one onto the GDD's Environmental Combat table. Explosive Lamp Oil is the explosive barrel: glass flask of burning oil in a rope net, lit wick, 2 hits to detonate, 30 damage within 96 px. Defensive Tome Stack is the destructible cover, and the sheet already gives the three damage stages the scaffold needs - strapped and locked, split with pages spilling, then shredded - across 5 hits. Scribe's Trap is the trap: a rusted frame of upturned PEN NIBS, shown disarmed, armed, and freshly triggered with violet ink on the points; 15 damage, re-arms after 2 s. Luminous Pigment Shell is the damage power-up that drops every 5th kill - teal, because teal is the player's colour, and a shell, which quietly ties it to the snail. Note the whole sheet is drawn at a 3/4 view matching the character rig.

ENEMY - Knight Snail (standard tier, armoured)



The knight-versus-snail joke is the single most common gag in real illuminated manuscript margins, which makes this the most on-theme enemy in the set. Circle-on-a-wedge silhouette. Rust shell fused to a steel great helm, violet slug foot, leather straps, a pennant and a couched lance. Slow mover, hard front, soft flank - the shape already tells the player how to fight it.

ENEMY - Hare Archer (standard tier, ranged)



Tall-ears silhouette, unmistakable at a glance and unmistakably different from the snail. Violet fur, rust hood and cape. This is the ranged enemy the GDD asks to hold 150-250 px and take cover - the drawn bow telegraphs that role before it fires a shot.

ENEMY - Grotesque (elite tier)



Hunched arc silhouette with a long curling tail. Rust hide over violet underside, the classic marginalia grotesque: a second grinning face set into the belly. Heavy ink contour, hatching inside the form rather than rendering. Reads as the big, slow, frightening one - use for the elite tier.

BOSS - the Ink Scribe (room 8)



Faceless hooded scribe dissolving into black ink, holding a quill. Robe in pale parchment going violet in shadow; the lower half is not a body at all but a spreading pool. The boss IS the ink that stains the dungeon floor, which ties the whole environment to him.